



Adaptability: Temba Bavuma showed how to bat on the Eden Gardens pitch with his short back-lift and soft hands. PTI

Anyway, the defeat to South Africa will hopefully open the eyes of those who matter to look at the heavy scorers in domestic cricket, who are used to playing on pitches where the ball spins and keeps low. The international players are so busy playing overseas that they do not have practice playing on domestic pitches, and so are found wanting.

Test batting demands patience and, more importantly, the willingness to leave your ego in the changing room. It does not matter if you get beaten and rapped on the leg guards. You do not have to try and tonk the ball out of the ground to show who is the boss. The only boss is the one who stays humble and accepts that at this level, the bowler will beat you, and so waits a bit till the scoreable ball comes along.

India also needs to understand the difference between

a Test all-rounder and a limited-overs all-rounder. A genuine Test all-rounder is someone who could make the eleven solely as a batter or as a bowler. A player who only offers a few overs or a few runs is not what Test cricket demands. A proper batter who can chip in with the ball is fine, just as a regular bowler who can hold up an end with the bat is valuable. But selecting a player who would not make the side purely as a batter or as a bowler might work in the short term, yet it does not add real value.

After this South Africa series, India will not play a home Test for over a year. All the more reason that there is clarity about the difference between Tests and limited-overs games, and about the requirements for the different formats.

If not, India could miss the World Test Championship final again, just as they did this June.



When India toured Australia last year, 17 wickets fell on day one in Perth. In Adelaide, 11 fell on the first day and 14 on the second. In Sydney, 11 wickets fell on day one and 15 on day two. Did the has-been have any complaints or caustic comments about those pitches? Absolutely not.